

Currying Flavour

Before his death, India's best-known food historian left behind a rich legacy

By Dilip Bobb



THE ILLUSTRATED FOODS OF INDIA

by K.T. ACHAYA
Oxford University Press
Price: Rs 395
Pages: 298

It's taken a while, but food writing has finally come to the boil in India. The India Rising story, pun intended, was itself a late bloomer, and it's only in the recent past that spreading affluence and twin-digit GDP growth rate has paired with an explosion of cosmopolitan eateries across the country and a radical new gastronomic adventurism among Indians. Food turned fad and initiated the arrival of celebrity chefs, iconic restaurants, popular food shows

on television channels, an assembly line of cook books and celebrity reviewers, prominent among them Sabina Sehgal Saikia, who died so tragically in the Mumbai mayhem. Saikia personified the power of the food writer to make or break new restaurants, a sure sign that eating out was serious business and that culinary horizons had, thankfully, gone way beyond butter chicken and vegetable manchurian.

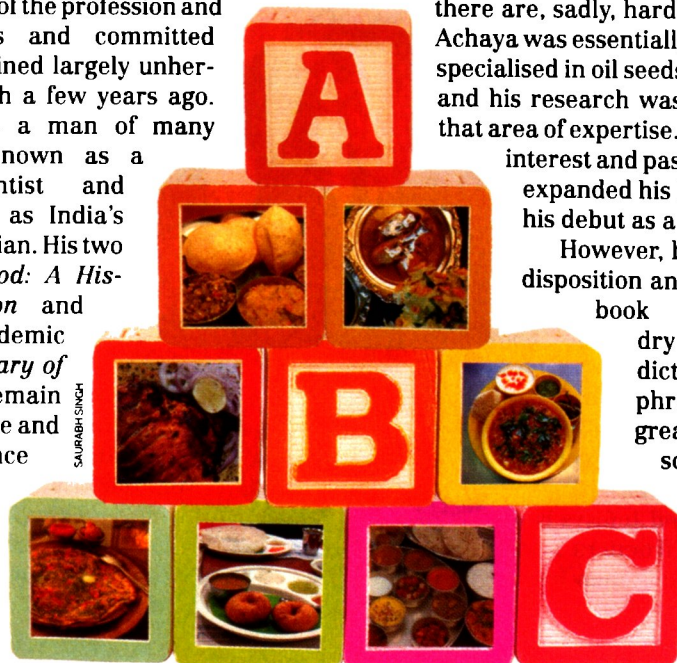
Despite all the glitz and glamour connected with restaurant reviews and food writing, the doyen of the profession and its most serious and committed practitioner remained largely unheralded till his death a few years ago. K.T. Achaya was a man of many talents, better known as a prominent scientist and scholar, but also as India's leading food historian. His two books: *Indian Food: A Historical Companion* and later, a less academic work, *The Dictionary of Indian Food* remain classics of the genre and the main reference points for the origins, history, variations and preparation of many of the

dishes we eat and what goes into their making. What made his books unique was the incredible amount of research he put into their preparation. To prolong his legacy, the publishers decided to stir them a bit, add new spices, simmer, and serve in a new version, *The Illustrated Foods of India*, which is a fusion of both. It's literally an alphabet soup of everything you wanted to know about the origins of Indian food and all that goes into its making, including arcane facts and background most of us are unaware of.

He informs us, for instance, that the ubiquitous idli, that South Indian staple, is actually of Indonesian origin, and that many of the ingredients and spices we take for granted as being indigenous in nature came to India by many of the ancient trade routes, via sea or land. *Dalchini* (cinnamon) came from China as did many fruits and, of course, tea. There were also numerous dishes that were bastardised by the British, like Patna Rice, Burdwan Stew and the renowned Byculla soufflé. Achaya relies mostly on ancient manuscripts like the *Ain-i-Akbari*, which described the food at Akbar's court, including some mouth-watering recipes.

Recipes, however, were not his thing and there are, sadly, hardly any in this book. Achaya was essentially a nutritionist who specialised in oil seeds and vegetable oils and his research was largely related to that area of expertise. It was his personal interest and passion for food which expanded his horizons and led to his debut as a food historian.

However, being of a scientific disposition and background, this book remains largely dry and technical, a dictionary of food and phrases, but like all great dishes, it contains some fascinating ingredients and hidden flavours to satisfy even the most jaded palate. ■



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